
The 5-Minute Morning Unlock

The sequence I do every morning, and why I
never skip it

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN SESSIONS BONUS PROTOCOL FOR the five minutes that change how your whole day goes.

This is the sequence I do every single morning. Takes five minutes. I don't skip it. Here's why.

Your body wakes up stiff. That's not a flaw — that's how it works. Overnight, you've been mostly still for 7-8 hours. Synovial fluid in your joints has settled. Connective tissue has cooled and tightened. Your nervous system has been in deep recovery mode, which means your muscles are essentially “off” and need to be turned back on before they do anything well.

Most people don't give them that time. They roll out of bed, walk straight into the bathroom, then the kitchen, then the car. Their body's first hour of the day is a cold-start under load. By 9 AM their low back already hurts and they don't know why.

The hurt comes from asking a cold body to perform without warming it up. The fix takes five minutes.

This is that protocol. Done before your feet hit the floor, or within the first 10 minutes of waking. Every day. No exceptions.

CHAPTER 1

Why morning specifically

THERE'S A REASON I'M SO INSISTENT ON THE morning version (rather than any other time):

Your tissue is at its stiffest first thing. Whatever stretching you do at this time produces the biggest relative change. Doing the same sequence at 3 PM produces less impact because your tissue is already warmer.

Your whole day stacks on top of how you start. If you start stiff, you stay stiff. If you unlock the tissue first thing, you spend the day in a more open, less-braced body. The morning sets the baseline.

It's the easiest time to actually do it. Once your day starts, things compete for your attention. In bed or right after, you have nothing competing. Five minutes is easy when nothing else is happening yet.

Build the habit at the time that requires the least willpower. That's the morning.

CHAPTER 2

The sequence — 5 moves, 5 minutes

YOU CAN DO PARTS OF THIS IN BED AND PARTS ON the floor. Or all of it on the floor. Or all of it in bed if you have a firm mattress. Doesn't matter. What matters is that you do it.

Move 1 — In-bed spinal twist (60 seconds)

Lie on your back. Bring your knees toward your chest, then let them fall to the right side. Let your shoulders stay flat against the bed. Turn your head to look left (opposite direction from your knees). Hold 30 seconds. Breathe slow.

Switch sides — knees to the left, head to the right. Hold 30 seconds.

This wakes up your spine through rotation. Often releases overnight tightness in the low back and mid-back before you even get up.

Move 2 — Cat-cow on hands and knees (90 seconds)

Get out of bed onto the floor (or do this from kneeling on the bed if your mattress is firm enough).

Hands and knees. Wrists under shoulders, knees under hips.

Inhale — drop your belly, lift your chest and head. (Cow.)

Exhale — round your back, tuck your chin. (Cat.)

10 reps. SLOW. Don't rush this. Let every segment of your spine actually move.

This is the wake-up call for the whole spine. After 10 slow reps, your back has moved more than it did the entire previous day.

Move 3 — Standing forward fold with bent knees (60 seconds)

Stand up. Feet hip-width apart, knees slightly bent (not locked).

Fold forward from the hips. Let your upper body hang completely. Let your head go heavy. Bend your knees enough that there's no strain anywhere — this isn't a hamstring stretch, this is a decompression.

Hang for 30 seconds. Breathe.

Slowly roll up vertebra by vertebra, head coming up last.

This decompresses the spine after overnight settling and lets gravity work for you.

Move 4 — Slow neck circles (60 seconds)

Standing tall. Slow neck circles — chin to chest, ear to shoulder, back, other ear, chin to chest.

5 each direction. SLOW. If you hear cracking or popping, that's normal — that's your neck saying thanks for the attention.

This restores neck range of motion that gets lost overnight (especially if you slept in a side-sleeping position with your neck slightly torqued).

Move 5 — Three deep belly breaths (30 seconds)

Stand or sit. Place one hand on your belly, one on your chest. Take three slow breaths where only the belly hand moves.

Inhale 4 counts through your nose. Exhale 6 counts through your mouth.

This activates the diaphragm, brings oxygen to tissues that have been in low-flow overnight, and signals your nervous system that it's time to come fully online for the day.

CHAPTER 3

The whole thing — start to finish

IN TOTAL: ABOUT 5 MINUTES. MAYBE 6 IF YOU go slow.

You can do it in pajamas. You can do it before coffee. You don't need any equipment, any space beyond a few feet of floor, or any specific time.

You can also stack it into other morning routines:

- Spinal twist while still in bed before getting up
- Cat-cow on the bedroom floor before getting dressed
- Standing forward fold + neck circles + breathing in the bathroom while waiting for the shower water to warm up

Whatever fits your morning. Just don't skip it.

CHAPTER 4

What you'll notice within a week

MOST PEOPLE DOING THIS CONSISTENTLY FOR 7 days report:

- Less morning stiffness
- Easier first hour of the day
- Less low back tightness throughout the day
- Slightly more energy in the morning
- A vague but real sense of “starting the day better”

These aren't dramatic. They're small. But they compound. After a month of doing this every morning, you'll have given your body something like 150 minutes of dedicated tissue care that it didn't get before — and the cumulative effect is real.

CHAPTER 5

When you'll want to skip it (and why you shouldn't)

YOU'LL BE TEMPTED TO SKIP ON BUSY MORNINGS.

Travel mornings. Mornings when something's gone wrong. Mornings when you're running late.

Those are the mornings you most need it.

When your day starts chaotic, your body's stress response activates immediately. The morning sequence is one of the only things that actively counteracts that stress activation BEFORE it sets the tone for the whole day.

The five minutes you save by skipping the sequence are not the same as the five minutes you spend doing it. The first five are spent on something urgent. The second five protect you from that urgency.

Trade up.

CHAPTER 6

Closing

FIVE MINUTES EVERY MORNING. THAT'S THE deal. Your body wakes up stiff — give it five minutes before you ask it to perform.

This is the smallest investment with the highest return I know in self-care. Five minutes a day. 25-30 minutes a week. Two hours a month. Twelve hours a year.

In exchange you get a body that starts every day from a more open, less-stiff baseline. Over years, the compounding effect is significant.

Start tomorrow morning. In bed. Spinal twist, both sides. That's the first move. Build the rest from there.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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